

— SPM 381 — CONSUMER BEHAVIOR IN SPORT

Fan Socialization

SPM381 Consumer Behavior in Sport | Fall 2026

Arcadia University Sport Management • Week 3

This Week

- Fan socialization
- Psychological Continuum Model (PCM)
- BIRGing & CORFing
- COFFing & Blasting
- Readings: Textbook p.120–142 & Wann (2001) p. 155–208 — see Table 8.2

Source – Readings are posted under Module 3 ‘Lecture Slide & Readings’

Announcement

- Your Current Topic Discussion Paper #1 due on Oct 04th, 11:59 pm
- Instructions are given on the course website — see 'Current Topic Discussion Papers' link



Know Your Fans

- Sport consumers can be categorized by their level of fandom — the degree to which they are (or are not) a fan
- *It's critical for managers to know whether someone is a fan of their team. Why?*
- This knowledge will influence marketing plan, ticket sales strategies, and management of seating patterns

Socialization

- *What is socialization?*
- "A process through which people learn the attitudes, values, and actions appropriate to individuals as members of a particular society" (see textbook p. 122)
- Through socialization, we learn the different roles in society and how to live and act within various roles

Fan Socialization

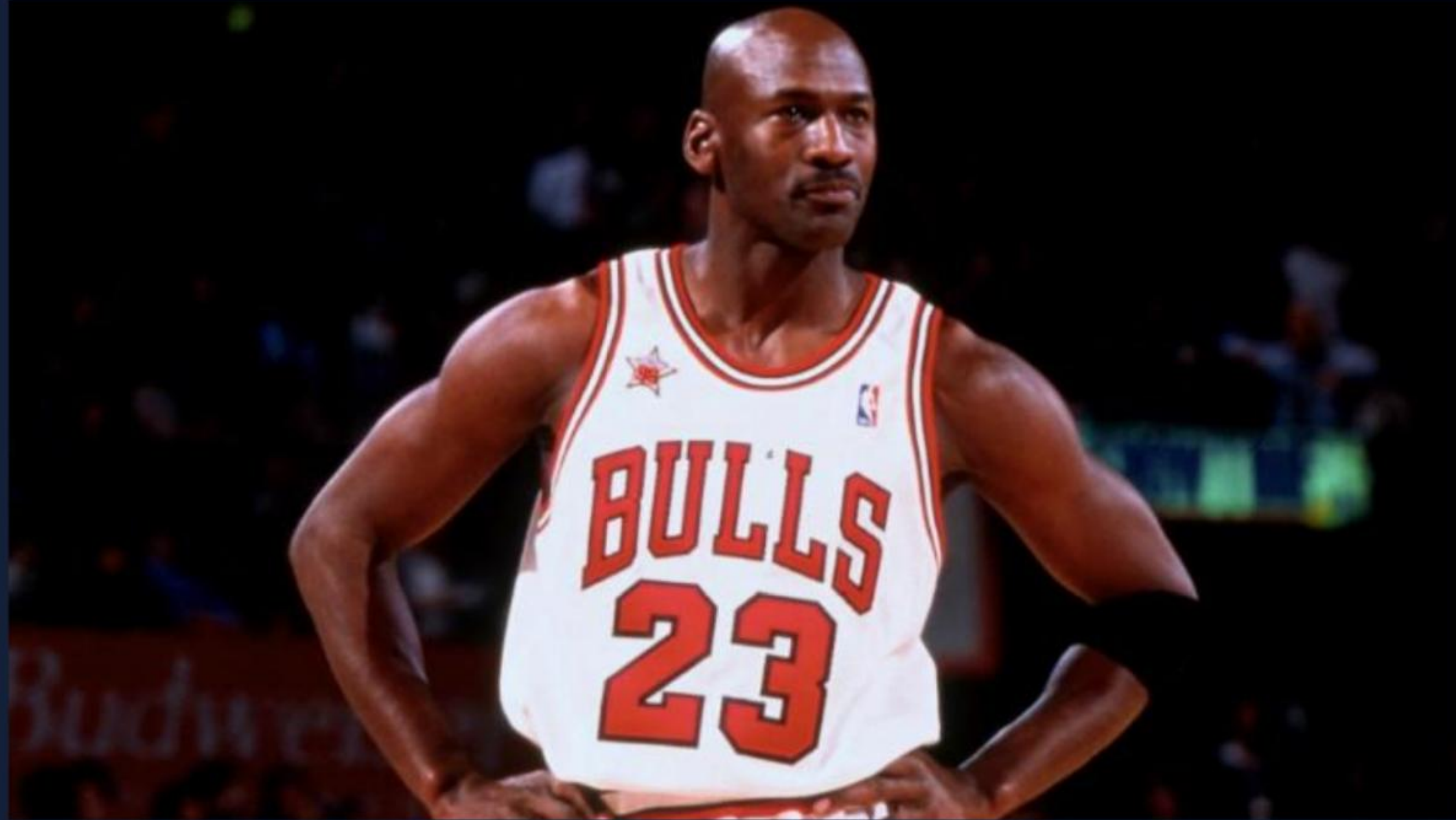
- We learn and internalize the attitudes, values, knowledge, and behaviors associated with fans of a team
- *How do people become a fan?*
- *When can you become a fan of a team?*
- People can be socialized into being fans at any point during the life span

Psychological Continuum Model



Source — Funk & James (2008), Figure 1 — Revised Psychological Continuum Model

- MJ was my favorite basketball player, and the Chicago Bulls were my favorite NBA team
- I was thinking I have to visit the United Center in Chicago
- In 2014, I made it — indeed
- Watch how he played: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=79MQ4_r7QZM





- Was great to be there to experience the Bulls game!!!



Fan Socialization

Kolbe and James (2000) conducted interviews, focus groups, and a mail survey with fans of the Cleveland Browns.

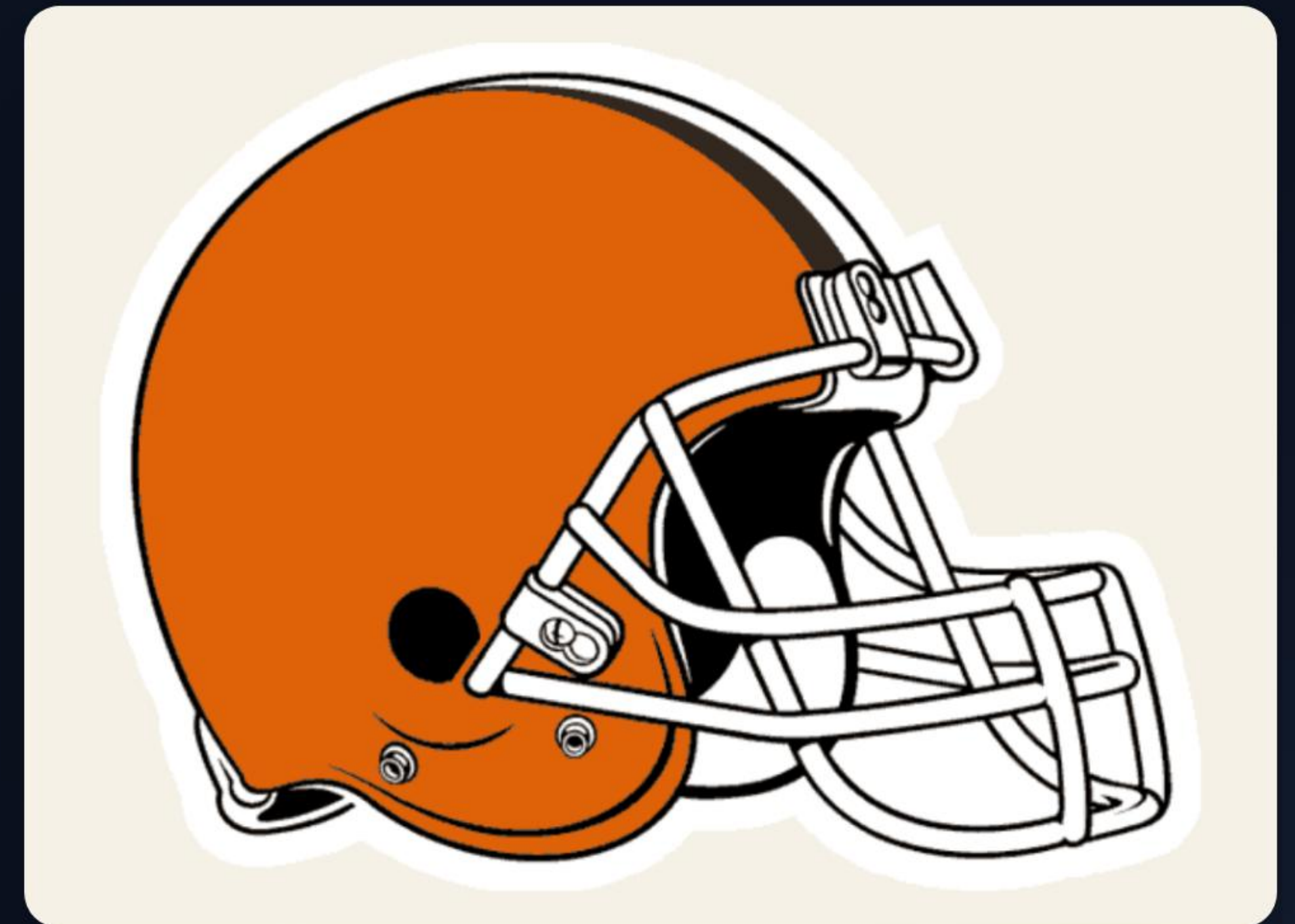
38.8%

of Browns fans named "father" as one person most influential in becoming a team fan

56%

had become true fans of the team prior to age 15 (most between ages 6–15)

- Fans were asked to identify (1) "the one person who had the most influence on them becoming a Browns fan," and (2) "how important various activities like attending games in person were to them becoming a fan"
- *What are the implications from this information?*
- *Any practical implications for sport management professions?*



Fan Socialization, cont.

- Kolbe and James (2000), cont.
- Adult fans indicated a distinct difference from the other groups: players and coaches contributed most to their attachment with a professional football team
- Emotional connection between the city and the team



Fan Socialization Across the Lifecycle

- A lifecycle perspective is used to consider how the various agents may influence fan socialization, and to what extent specific agents may have more or less impact at different points in one's life

Fan Socialization Across the Lifecycle

A lifecycle perspective considers how various agents influence fan socialization at each life stage.

1

Childhood — birth through pre-adolescence

2

Adolescence — 10 to 18

3

Young adult — college years through 20s

4

Older adult — 30 and above

- The four-stage perspective focuses on key life stages and explains how the various agents may influence a person's connection to a sports team relative to each stage
- If we think about becoming a fan from a lifecycle perspective, most people are socialized into the role by six socialization agents, either individually or in some combination

Fan Socialization Across the Lifecycle

- *Socializing agents — what caused you to become a fan?*
- Family
- Friends
- Media
- Organization (e.g., Arcadia University)
- Geography (e.g., Philadelphia, NY, NJ)
- Participation in a sport
- Various socializing agents have a differential impact at various stages!!!

— SIX SOCIALIZING AGENTS

Fan Socialization Across the Lifecycle



— SECTION

Self-Presentational Strategies: Fan Reactions to the Game Outcomes

BIRGing and CORFing

STRATEGY	DEFINITION
STRATEGIES FOLLOWING TEAM SUCCESS	
1. Basking In Reflected Glory (BIRGing)	Involves increasing one's association with successful teams to enhance psychological health.
2. Cutting Off Future Failure (COFFing)	Involves decreasing one's association with a currently successful team to protect one's future psychological health should the team perform poorly at a later date.
STRATEGIES FOLLOWING TEAM FAILURE	
1. Cutting Off Reflected Failure (CORFing)	Involves decreasing one's association with an unsuccessful team to protect one's psychological health.
2. Blasting	Involves out-group derogation and/or aggression to regain one's psychological health.

Source – Table 8.2; Wann et al. (2011), p. 169 (this week's reading)

BIRGing and CORFing, cont.

- Cialdini et al. (1976) conducted college football field studies to demonstrate the BIRG phenomenon
- Measured students' tendency to wear university-identifying apparel
- The proportion of students who wore university-identifying apparel increased following a win by the university's football team
- A team identification is influenced by external group identities when the team represents the external identities well



BIRGing and CORFing, cont.

- Telephoned respondents and asked them to describe a recent game involving their university's football team
- "We won" & "We got beat" vs. "They lost"
- Participants were more likely to use the pronoun "we" to describe a recent win, and "they" to describe a defeat



Blasting

- CORFing doesn't seem to be an option for truly loyal fans under their favorite team's poor performance (Trail & James, 2015)
- Fans (to maintain their own self-esteem) would derogate or blame the referees, the other team, or even the other team's fans (i.e., out-group)
- Why? Fans want to avoid the perception of failure by blaming poor performance on some factor other than the team's actual performance



BIRGing and CORFing, cont.

- CORFing — fans will try to cut off reflected failure when a team or player does not do well
- Not all people CORF when a team loses; true fans don't CORF (Trail & James, 2015)
- Ex) People who were not identified with the NY Yankees were much more likely to CORF after the Yankees lost the World Series against the Florida Marlins in 2003 (Kwon et al., 2008)
- BIRGing and CORFing exist on two separate parallel continuums (Trail & James, 2015)



Thank you!